

68 Bathsheba

Taken by a king, grieved as a mother, and honored at last as the queen mother of Solomon.

Bathsheba was the wife of Uriah the Hittite, one of David's best soldiers. While Uriah was at war, King David saw her from his roof, sent for her, and committed adultery with her. When she was pregnant, David had her husband killed. Bathsheba mourned Uriah, became David's wife, and lost the baby. Scripture places the blame firmly on David. Yet God gave her another son, Solomon, and years later she stepped forward with Nathan to make sure Solomon became king. She is last seen honored at her son's right hand, and Matthew names her in Jesus' family line.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Bat-sheva</i> , "daughter of an oath" or "of seven"
Family	Daughter of Eliam, or Ammiel (2 Samuel 11:3; 1 Chronicles 3:5)
Husbands	Uriah the Hittite; then King David (2 Samuel 11:3, 27)
Sons	Shimea, Shobab, Nathan and Solomon (1 Chronicles 3:5)
When	David's reign and the start of Solomon's, c. 1000–970 BC (rough)
Key people	David, Uriah the Hittite, Nathan the prophet, Solomon, Adonijah
New Testament	Matthew 1:6, as "her that had been the wife of Urias"

"And the king rose up to meet her, and bowed himself unto her, and sat down on his throne, and caused a seat to be set for the king's mother; and she sat on his right hand."

1 Kings 2:19, KJV

The life of Bathsheba

Dates are approximate and rough (BC). The events of 2 Samuel 11–12 fall in the middle of David's reign in Jerusalem. The events of 1 Kings 1–2 date to c. 970 BC.

During the Ammonite war	● Taken by the king David stays home while the army is at war. From his roof he sees Bathsheba bathing, learns she is Uriah's wife, sends for her and commits adultery with her. She sends word: "I am with child." <i>2 Samuel 11:1–5</i>
Soon after	● Widowed and remarried Uriah is killed at Rabbah on David's secret orders. Bathsheba mourns her husband. When the mourning is over, David brings her to his house as his wife, and she bears a son. <i>2 Samuel 11:26–27</i>
Seven days of illness	● Loses her child After Nathan the prophet confronts David, the child falls sick. David fasts and prays, but on the seventh day the child dies. <i>2 Samuel 12:14–23</i>
Afterwards	● Mother of Solomon David comforts Bathsheba, and she bears another son, Solomon. "The LORD loved him," and through Nathan God names him Jedidiah, "beloved of the LORD." <i>2 Samuel 12:24–25</i>
c. 970 BC	● Speaks up for Solomon When Adonijah claims the throne, Nathan urges Bathsheba to remind David of his promise. She speaks to the king, and David swears that Solomon will reign. <i>1 Kings 1:11–31</i>
c. 970 BC	● Queen mother Solomon bows to her and seats her at his right hand. She brings Adonijah's request for Abishag, and Solomon sees in it a new bid for the throne. <i>1 Kings 2:13–25</i>

Key activities

Readers differ on how much choice Bathsheba had when the king sent for her. Some see her as sharing the guilt. Others stress that a subject could hardly refuse a king. The text itself lays the blame on David: "the thing that David had done displeased the LORD" (2 Samuel 11:27; see 12:7-9).

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- 1 Told David the truth.** When she found she was pregnant, she sent word to the king. *2 Samuel 11:5*
 - 2 Mourned her husband.** When she heard that Uriah was dead, she "mourned for her husband." *2 Samuel 11:26*
 - 3 Grieved her first child.** Her son born to David died as Nathan had said. *2 Samuel 12:14-19*
 - 4 Bore Solomon.** She became the mother of the son God loved and chose to build the temple. *2 Samuel 12:24-25; 1 Chronicles 22:9-10*
 - 5 Reminded the king of his promise.** She told David, "thou swarest by the LORD thy God unto thine handmaid" that Solomon would reign. *1 Kings 1:15-21*
 - 6 Served as queen mother.** She sat at Solomon's right hand and brought requests to him. *1 Kings 2:19-20*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Bathsheba.

Old Testament

2 Samuel 11-12	David's sin, her lost child, Solomon's birth
1 Kings 1:11-31; 2:13-25	Secures Solomon's throne; serves as queen mother
1 Chronicles 3:5	Called Bath-shua, daughter of Ammiel, mother of four
Psalms 51	Its title links it to Nathan's visit after Bath-sheba
Echo: Psalm 147:3	He heals the broken in heart

New Testament

Matthew 1:6	"Her that had been the wife of Urias," with Tamar, Rahab, Ruth
Luke 3:31	Luke traces Jesus' line through her son Nathan
Echo: Luke 1:52	God exalts them of low degree

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How does 2 Samuel 11 describe what David did, and what does it say of Bathsheba?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Matthew calls her "her that had been the wife of Urias" instead of using her name?
3. *Apply:* Bathsheba lived through loss she did not choose. How can your group support someone carrying grief caused by another person's sin?
4. *Apply:* Years later Bathsheba spoke up at a key moment. Is there a situation where you need to speak up for what is right?